

BRAND & INTERFACE DIRECTION / V1.0

WORLDS

RUN THE STORY.

An intentional visual system for a premium authored running game.

Built for the moment before the run, the glance during it, and the memory afterward.

NORTH STAR

Prepared for product, design, engineering, story, audio and demo production.

01 / DIRECTION

The interface gets out of the story's way.

Worlds is cinematic in content and athletic in operation. The product must feel authored, immediate and trustworthy without borrowing the visual clutter of conventional games.

DESIGN THESIS

Use NRC-level restraint for structure and run-time usability. Put the drama in the world art, voice performance and responsive states - not in ornamental interface chrome.

The three jobs

MOMENT	USER NEED	DESIGN RESPONSE
Before the run	Choose quickly and feel anticipation.	Editorial world art, one clear recommendation, plain duration and readiness information.
During the run	Understand the situation in under one second.	Route first, one active story objective, high-contrast metrics and voice-led feedback.
After the run	Feel that this run mattered.	A narrative recap tied to exact movement, decisions, consequences and character state.

What this is not

- Not a fantasy-themed running dashboard.
- Not an audiobook player with GPS added beneath it.
- Not a chat interface disguised as a game director.
- Not an endless catalogue of interchangeable AI stories.
- Not a stat-heavy training tool competing with the narrative for attention.

02 / BRAND PLATFORM

A world you physically enter.

The brand promise is agency: real movement creates authored consequences. Every line of copy and every product state should reinforce that contract.

ELEMENT	APPROVED EXPRESSION
Category	Audio-first running game
Core promise	Premium authored adventures where your run controls the story.
Tagline	Run the Story.
Philosophy	The world is authored. The experience is adaptive.
Creator framing	The writer creates the world. The runner determines the story.
Proof	Direction chooses paths. Pace changes encounters. Stops uncover moments. Failure creates story.

Brand character

WE ARE	WE ARE NOT
Cinematic	Decorative
Immediate	Hyperactive
Confident	Aggressive
Authored	Synthetic
Athletic	Clinical
Consequential	Punitive

THE EMOTIONAL TEST

A runner should feel summoned, not onboarded; accompanied, not instructed; remembered, not scored.

03 / VOICE

Short. Human. Inside the world.

Product language is calm and exact. Character language may be emotional, but the interface never performs excitement with punctuation, hype or generic fantasy phrasing.

Interface voice

PRINCIPLE	USE	AVOID
Direct	Start run	Begin your epic journey
Situated	The northern road is still open.	A new path has been unlocked!
Consequential	Mara remembers you stayed.	+10 relationship points
Physical	Hold this pace.	Sprint for 20 seconds
Specific	You reached the gate in 04:12.	Great job, runner!

Mechanics become dialogue

SYSTEM EVENT	DIEGETIC LINE
Turn left	The forest. Good. Stay beneath the branches.
Increase pace	They heard us. Move.
Slow down	Torches ahead. Quiet your steps.
Stop	Wait. There is someone under the bridge.
Fail challenge	The gate closes. Mara takes the lower path alone.

Capitalization and punctuation

- Sentence case everywhere except the wordmark and small utility labels.
- One exclamation mark is already one too many in product UI.
- Use numerals for time, pace and distance. Write narrative quantities naturally in dialogue.
- Never expose system language such as event detected, branch selected or AI response.

04 / IDENTITY

The name is the mark.

Worlds needs the confidence of a media platform, not a fantasy crest. Begin with a strong wordmark and a single route symbol; add no lore-specific ornament to the parent brand.

WORLDS

RUN THE STORY.

Wordmark direction

- Set WORLDS in a tightly tracked geometric grotesk, uppercase, heavy weight.
- Customise the W with a subtle inward route cut; it should read as typography before symbolism.
- Keep the silhouette horizontal and compact enough for a top bar, app launch and audio cover tile.
- Use black, warm white or Torch only. No gradients, bevels, outlines or genre textures.

Symbol direction

A continuous line that changes direction once and terminates in a small point. It suggests route, choice and forward motion without becoming a map pin, compass or play button.

LOCKUP	USE
Wordmark	Primary: launch, campaign art, partner materials, store presence.
Route symbol	Small spaces: app icon, map marker, audio speaking state.
Wordmark + tagline	Brand moments only. Never inside the active-run HUD.

GUARDRAIL

Individual story worlds may have expressive title treatments. The Worlds parent identity remains neutral enough to host horror, fantasy, science fiction and mystery with equal authority.

05 / TYPOGRAPHY

Athletic scale. Editorial rhythm.

The system uses one practical sans family and one compressed data face. Hierarchy comes from scale, weight and spacing - never from decorative type effects.

PRIMARY FAMILY / INTER

The forest could hide us.

Inter ExtraBold / 28 pt / -1% tracking equivalent

Mara remembers that you stayed.

Inter SemiBold / 17 pt / sentence case

The road narrows beyond the gate. You have enough light to reach the ridge, but not enough to return the same way.

Inter Regular / 11 pt / 130% line height

PERFORMANCE NUMERALS / ARIAL NARROW

04:12 5'28" 3.84 KM

Arial Narrow Bold / tabular-style data treatment / never for prose

Production recommendation

Bundle Inter with the product so the interface has the same typographic voice on iOS and Android. Use Inter Display for large campaign and screen titles. Arial Narrow is acceptable for hackathon performance numerals; replace it with a licensed or bundled condensed family before broad distribution.

06 / TYPE SYSTEM

Every size has a job.

The scale is intentionally narrow. Screens should rarely need more than four roles at once.



TOKEN	SPEC	USE
display-01	40 / 40, Heavy	Campaign hero, completion moment
display-02	32 / 34, Heavy	World title, primary route prompt
title-01	24 / 28, Bold	Screen title
title-02	20 / 24, Demi	Section title, character state
body-01	16 / 22, Medium	Primary mobile body and prompts
body-02	14 / 20, Regular	Supporting copy
label-01	12 / 14, Bold, +4%	Controls and metadata
micro-01	11 / 13, Demi, +6%	Map labels and captions
metric-01	44 / 42, DIN Bold	Primary active metric
metric-02	24 / 24, DIN Bold	Secondary metric

Rules

- Use sentence case for all titles except the wordmark and utility labels.
- Keep campaign titles to two lines; art direction must accommodate real title length.
- Use Heavy only for decisive moments. A screen filled with heavy type has no hierarchy.
- Never place text directly over a busy face or plot-critical artwork without a controlled scrim.
- Metrics use fixed-width numeral behavior to prevent layout shifting while the runner moves.

07 / COLOR SHEET

One signal in a quiet field.

The core palette is warm rather than digital. Torch marks action, live state and narrative consequence; it is not a decorative accent sprayed across every screen.

SWATCH	TOKEN	VALUE	ROLE
	Ink	#0B0C0E	Primary background, text, control surfaces
	Paper	#F4F2ED	Warm light background, cards, editorial space
	White	#FFFFFF	High-contrast text and clean surfaces
	Torch	#FF4F2E	Primary action, active route, live audio state
	Ash	#686A70	Secondary text and inactive metadata
	Line	#D8D6D0	Rules, dividers and quiet outlines

USAGE RATIO

Aim for 70% Ink or Paper, 20% imagery, 8% neutral structure and no more than 2% Torch on a typical product screen.

Core combinations

COMBINATION	USE
Paper / Ink	Library, world detail, recap reading
Ink / White	Active run, launch, cinematic transitions
Torch / Ink	Primary button and selected route
Ink / Torch	Live state indicator, small highlight only

08 / FUNCTIONAL COLOR

Color communicates state, not genre.

Story artwork may vary by world. Interface colors stay stable so the runner learns what is actionable, live, successful or dangerous.

SWATCH	TOKEN	VALUE	ROLE
	Route / selected	#FF4F2E	Current path and primary action
	Route / alternate	#536DFE	Available but unselected route
	Discovery	#8B5CF6	Optional scene or unresolved mystery
	Resource	#F3A712	Supply, time or scarce opportunity
	Success	#198754	Challenge resolved; never as constant celebration
	Danger	#D92D20	Immediate physical or narrative threat
	Stealth	#234C3B	Reduced pace / concealment state

Accessibility rules

- Never communicate challenge outcome with color alone. Pair it with a word, icon change, haptic and audio response.
- Torch is designed for dark surfaces. On light surfaces, use Torch Dark for small text and thin strokes.
- Keep primary text at WCAG AA contrast or better; active-run information should target AAA where practical.
- Route colors require differentiated line patterns or terminal shapes for color-vision resilience.

09 / LAYOUT

Designed for a moving body.

Worlds uses large targets, clear edges and predictable placement. Elegance comes from rhythm, not density.

TOKEN	VALUE	APPLICATION
Base unit	4 px	All spacing resolves to the base unit
Screen gutter	20 px	Standard phone content inset
Section gap	32 px	Major content separation
Card radius	16 px	World and recap cards
Control radius	999 px	Primary run controls only
Touch target	48 px min	Any interactive control
Primary CTA	56 px	Start, resume and finish actions
Bottom safety	24 px + inset	Thumb comfort and device safe area

Composition

- Use a 4-column mobile grid before the run and a simpler edge-anchored layout during the run.
- Allow one dominant object per screen: artwork, route, choice or recap statement.
- Avoid nested cards. A surface should not need a card inside a card to establish hierarchy.
- Place the most consequential action in the lower third, reachable by one thumb.
- During motion, no essential information may depend on horizontal scrolling, tiny map labels or long reading.

GLANCE TEST

At jogging motion and arm's length, a runner must be able to identify the current objective and primary action in under one second.

10 / PRODUCT ARCHITECTURE

Four places. One continuous story.

The navigation is deliberately smaller than a standard fitness or streaming app. Worlds should not reveal organizational complexity to the runner.

DESTINATION	PURPOSE	PRIMARY CONTENT
Home	Return to the story	Continue card, suggested worlds, recent run
Worlds	Browse intentionally	Curated collections, genres, creator worlds
Journey	See what changed	Campaign timeline, relationships, discoveries
You	Manage the runner	Run history, goals, audio, safety, account

Persistent control

When a run is active, navigation disappears. A compact live-run pill may appear only if the runner temporarily leaves the run screen. It shows elapsed time, one state label and a return action - never a miniature dashboard.

Home hierarchy

1. Continue the current campaign. This is the largest element and contains one decisive action.
2. Choose the shape of today's run: 15, 30 or 45 minutes, recovery, interval or open run.
3. Discover one editorially selected world or creator collection.
4. Review the last consequence in a single sentence.

11 / HOME & LIBRARY

Show worlds, not content inventory.

Discovery should feel curated and cinematic. The interface never advertises volume with endless rows of near-identical tiles.

Continue card

LAYER	SPECIFICATION
Artwork	Full-bleed cinematic key art; subject offset from copy and controls.
Eyebrow	CURRENT JOURNEY / world or campaign name
Title	The immediate story objective, not an episode number.
State line	One remembered consequence: 'Mara is injured. The northern gate is closed.'
Action	Continue - 30 min; duration is part of the decision.

Collection logic

- Worlds Originals - the quality benchmark and default first-run experience.
- Creator Worlds - lead with creator name and a clear authored-by signal.
- For tonight - mood and duration, not algorithmic personality claims.
- Your unfinished stories - progress expressed as narrative state, not percentages.

Tile rules

Use a 4:5 poster ratio for worlds and a 16:9 landscape ratio for featured campaigns. Never bake essential labels into artwork. Display duration, audio readiness and campaign status outside the image with consistent UI typography.

EDITORIAL DISCIPLINE

If every world is featured, none is. One hero, one secondary collection and one continuation state are enough for the hackathon home screen.

12 / WORLD DETAIL & PRE-RUN

Build desire, then remove friction.

The story page sells the emotional promise. The pre-run sheet converts that promise into a safe, ready session.

World detail order

1. Key art and title treatment.
2. One-sentence hook written in-world.
3. A 20-30 second voice preview with captions.
4. What movement controls: direction, pace, stops or a specific combination.
5. Campaign status or new-story entry point.
6. Creator, cast and authored-world credits.

Pre-run sheet

ROW	BEHAVIOR
Run shape	15 / 30 / 45 min or distance. Recommend one based on story state.
Intensity	Recovery / steady / challenge. Explain in physical terms.
Audio	Headphones connected, voice preview passed, volume safe.
Location	GPS ready and route sensitivity clear.
Safety	One concise reminder; never theatricalize real-world risk.
Primary action	Start story. Full-width, 56 px, Torch on Ink.

START-STATE RULE

The first authored line should begin within two seconds of starting. Do not place a branded countdown, tutorial carousel or loading monologue between the runner and the world.

The route is the stage.

The active experience is a map, an objective and an audio presence. Everything else is subordinate.

Default hierarchy

ZONE	CONTAINS	RULE
Top	Elapsed time + one optional metric	Never more than two numbers at once.
Center	Route and runner position	High contrast, simplified geography, no map clutter.
Lower third	Current in-world objective	One line; disappears when understood.
Bottom	Audio state, pause, safety	Large controls; protected from accidental taps.

Route treatment

- Completed route: 40% neutral line. Current path: Torch, 5-6 px. Alternatives: thinner, lower contrast.
- At a branch, simplify nearby map detail and increase path separation before showing any text.
- The runner marker points in the direction of travel; it should not resemble a generic location pin.
- Story locations appear only when relevant and use authored names: North Gate, Alder Wood, Bell Tower.

Metric restraint

Default to elapsed time and current pace. Distance is available by tapping the metric group or through an audio check-in. Heart rate appears only when it changes the designed challenge or safety state.

SCREEN-OFF CONTRACT

Every essential story decision and challenge can be understood through audio and movement alone. The screen confirms; it does not command.

14 / CHOICES & CHALLENGES

Movement is the control surface.

The UI visualizes what the world has already made understandable through dialogue. It must never turn the moment into a multiple-choice form.

Direction choice

1. Character names the physical possibilities in-world.
2. Map subtly reveals the corresponding route branches.
3. Runner changes direction; the selected route brightens immediately.
4. A short haptic confirms recognition.
5. Character acknowledges the choice within the next natural breath.

Pace challenge

PHASE	VISUAL	AUDIO / HAPTIC
Set	A thin target band appears around current pace.	Character creates urgency; no synthetic beep.
Respond	Runner marker and route pulse once as pace changes.	One light haptic at threshold entry.
Hold	Band contracts; no confetti or score accumulation.	World sound carries the tension.
Resolve	One-word state: ESCAPED / SEEN / INJURED.	Character reaction and consequence line.

Failure

Failure is presented with the same visual dignity as success. No red full-screen punishment, buzzer or retry modal. The interface states what changed, then the story continues.

EXAMPLE CONSEQUENCE

THE GATE CLOSED / Mara took the lower path alone. This is a story state, not a fitness grade.

15 / AUDIO PRESENCE

Voice is the interface.

Audio state must be legible without resembling a music player. The runner is hearing a living scene, not consuming a track.

STATE	VISUAL BEHAVIOR
Character speaking	Small route symbol pulses once on phrase onset; character name appears only if needed.
Narration	No avatar or chat bubble. A quiet waveform line may indicate live playback.
Director reacting	Never label AI or generation. Show 'The world is responding...' only if latency exceeds the designed threshold.
Music / ambience	No persistent track title. Credits are available after the run.
Connection degraded	Protect immersion with authored fallback audio, then show a plain recovery status.

Latency behavior

- Under 400 ms: immediate acknowledgement feels live.
- 400-1,200 ms: bridge with breath, ambience or a character reaction sound.
- Over 1,200 ms: play an authored compatible line rather than expose silence or a spinner.
- Never repeat a detected choice while waiting for dialogue. One acknowledgement is enough.

Controls

Pause, volume and captions remain available. Skip-forward is not a primary control because story timing and movement are connected. If a runner misses a line, offer a single 'Repeat last line' action and preserve state.

16 / RECAP & PROGRESSION

Remember the run as a story.

The recap is the payoff for the entire product promise. Lead with consequence; let fitness data support it.

Recap order

1. A single authored headline based on the ending state: You reached the bell tower alone.
2. A short spoken recap in the voices of characters who survived the run.
3. A route map annotated with two or three meaningful story moments.
4. Consequences: relationship, injury, resource, discovery and unresolved threat.
5. Run facts: duration, distance and pace, visually quieter than the story result.
6. One next-story hook with an honest minimum recommended run length.

Campaign timeline

ENTRY TYPE	EXAMPLE
Decision	You entered Alder Wood instead of returning to the village.
Performance	You outran the riders for 01:42.
Consequence	Mara was injured at the northern gate.
Discovery	The crest beneath the bridge matches the king's seal.
Relationship	Ilan trusts you enough to reveal the hidden road.

SHAREABLE ARTIFACT

Generate a restrained story card: world art, one consequence line and a simplified route. Do not turn the recap into a generic fitness achievement template.

17 / COMPONENT LANGUAGE

Fewer components. Stronger states.

A coherent MVP can be built from a small, rigorously specified set. Each component must have a reason to exist during motion.

COMPONENT	REQUIRED STATES	NOTES
Primary button	default / pressed / loading / disabled	Torch fill; action verb first; no icon unless essential.
World card	new / active / complete / locked	Artwork-led; state outside image; one metadata line.
Route line	past / current / alternate / selected / blocked	Color plus line pattern or terminal shape.
Runner marker	moving / stopped / uncertain GPS	Direction-aware; uncertainty shown as radius, not alarm.
Objective label	enter / active / resolved	One sentence; auto-dismiss after comprehension window.
Audio presence	speaking / ambience / buffering / fallback	Never a chat bubble or assistant avatar.
Consequence card	positive / adverse / unresolved	Same structure and dignity across outcomes.
Metric cluster	default / challenge / safety	Maximum one primary and two secondary values.

Iconography

Use a 2 px rounded-line icon set with optical rather than mathematical centering. Icons identify familiar actions only: pause, volume, captions, location and safety. Story concepts should be named, illustrated or voiced - not reduced to a generic icon library.

Movement should feel causal.

Animation is used to connect the runner's action to the world's response. It should never create spectacle that competes with actual movement.

EVENT	MOTION	DURATION
Route selected	Alternate route fades; selected line draws forward from runner.	220-320 ms
Pace threshold	Target band settles around current pace; no continuous bounce.	180 ms
Objective enters	Fade + 8 px upward translation.	200 ms
Consequence lands	Short hold, then text reveal in two beats.	400-600 ms
Audio phrase onset	One subtle pulse of the route symbol.	160 ms

Haptic grammar

- Recognition: one light tap when movement is confidently understood.
- Success: two restrained taps, close together.
- Threat or safety: one firm tap; reserve it so it keeps meaning.
- Failure: no punitive buzz. Use the consequence's own audio and one grounded tap if needed.

Reduced motion

All state changes remain understandable through contrast, shape, text, haptic and audio. Reduced-motion mode removes route drawing, parallax and pulsing while preserving instantaneous state recognition.

19 / ART DIRECTION

Human stakes at landscape scale.

World artwork establishes genre and emotional promise. It should look commissioned, cinematic and specific - never like a generic AI fantasy wallpaper.

Image principles

- Show a decisive place and a human point of view, not a collage of every character and threat.
- Use real directional composition: paths, light and gaze should lead toward the title or action area.
- Leave intentional negative space for responsive crops and interface copy.
- Favor tactile atmosphere - weather, distance, material, breath, light - over excessive detail.
- Maintain one art director, color script and character bible per world so assets feel authored across screens.

Crop system

RATIO	USE	COMPOSITION REQUIREMENT
4:5	World poster	Subject center-left or center-right; title-safe upper quarter.
16:9	Featured campaign	Narrative action on one side; copy-safe opposite third.
1:1	Audio / share	Readable silhouette and one focal relationship.
9:16	Launch / transition	Depth and forward direction; safe center corridor.

AI IMAGERY GUARDRAIL

If generative tools are used during the hackathon, treat outputs as raw production material: art-direct, composite, retouch and enforce character continuity. Never ship an unedited first-generation image as key art.

20 / HACKATHON SEQUENCE

Design the proof, not the platform.

The demo should make the interaction undeniable before explaining the technology. These screens and transitions deserve nearly all available polish.

BEAT	ON SCREEN	WHAT THE AUDIENCE UNDERSTANDS
1 / Select	One premium world and a 30-minute recommendation.	This is curated entertainment.
2 / Begin	Key art gives way to route; voice starts immediately.	Audio is the primary interface.
3 / Choose	Three routes emerge as the character describes them.	Movement selects the path.
4 / React	The chosen line brightens; dialogue names the choice.	The world noticed instantly.
5 / Challenge	Pace target appears inside the route state.	Physical performance matters.
6 / Consequence	Failure or success changes a character state.	Failure creates story.
7 / Stop	An optional discovery becomes available while stationary.	Stopping is also input.
8 / Recap	Route, choices and character consequence resolve together.	The story remembers this exact run.

Polish priority

Spend disproportionate effort on audio transition timing, the route-choice acknowledgement, the pace-state change and the personalized recap. A shallow library can still feel intentional; a delayed reaction cannot.

21 / DESIGN REVIEW

Protect the idea from familiar shortcuts.

Use this page as the final critique checklist before a screen, prototype or demo build is accepted.

REJECT IF...	BECAUSE...
The active run resembles a dense fitness dashboard.	The story has lost visual priority.
A choice appears as three tappable answer cards.	Movement is no longer the interface.
The UI says AI, generated, event or branch.	The directing system has broken immersion.
Every state uses Torch or a dramatic animation.	The signal color and motion no longer carry meaning.
Failure is framed as a score loss or retry prompt.	Consequence has become punishment.
World art determines button colors or core navigation.	The platform loses learned consistency.
Copy sounds motivational, epic or generic.	The authored voice has been replaced by product hype.
The recap leads with calories, pace or badges.	The run did not become a story.

MVP handoff tokens

Ink #0B0C0E / Paper #F4F2ED / Torch #FF4F2E / Torch Dark #C92D14 / Ash #686A70 / Line #D8D6D0

Inter: ExtraBold, Bold, SemiBold, Medium, Regular / Arial Narrow Bold: performance numerals only

Spacing: 4, 8, 12, 16, 20, 24, 32, 40, 48 / Radii: 8, 16, 999 / Touch: 48 minimum, 56 primary

FINAL TEST

If the UI can be mistaken for an audiobook app, add agency. If it can be mistaken for a fantasy game, remove decoration. If it can be mistaken for a run tracker, restore the story.

APPENDIX

Reference posture

This direction borrows interaction discipline, not trade dress. Worlds should learn from proven run-time patterns while retaining its own typography, color, content model and narrative behavior.

Primary references

REFERENCE	WHAT TO STUDY	SOURCE
Nike Run Club	Guided-run discovery, start flow, glanceable run metrics and confident restraint.	nike.com/nrc-app
Apple Workouts	Active-workout hierarchy, safety and prioritization of essential metrics.	developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines/workouts
Zombies, Run!	Screen-off narrative fitness behavior, mission framing and audio continuity.	support.zombiesrungame.com
Premium streaming	Commissioned key art, continuation hierarchy and editorial curation.	Pattern reference only; do not clone layout or branding.

Originality boundary

Do not reproduce another product's proprietary artwork, icons, exact screen compositions, copy, branded typefaces or distinctive trade dress. The useful lesson from NRC is disciplined hierarchy: one clear action, strong typography, restrained color and low cognitive load while moving.

Decision status

DECISION	STATUS
Core visual direction	Recommended for prototype
Torch accent color	Recommended; verify on target devices
Inter	Recommended; open family to bundle cross-platform
Arial Narrow	Hackathon numeric role; replace or license for distribution
Wordmark customization	Requires designer refinement before public launch
Functional color accessibility	Requires contrast audit in final components